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-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

EXPRESS special

INFRA PROJECT COSTS MAY SEE RISE

Small firms flag price hike in projects using PVC pipes as Govt curbs input imports

Big local producers of S-PVC say floor price justified, China, others dumping resin cheap

Ravi Dutta Mishra
& Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 1

E. EXPLAINED

How supply gap affects user industry

MICRO, SMALL and medium enterprises (MSMEs) that make pipes have flagged an impending increase in irrigation and housing project costs after the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) imposed a six-month restriction on imports of a key input used for manufacturing these, Suspension Polyvinyl Chloride (S-PVC) resin.

The DGFT measure came on July 24, after the Finance Ministry last year declined to accept the Commerce and Industry Ministry's recommendation to impose an anti-dumping duty (ADD) on the item. Such duty recommendations from the Commerce and Industry Ministry are rejected by the Finance Ministry when "public interest" is involved. S-PVC resin is used across sectors, from irrigation pipes and conduits to electrical wires used in construction.

MSME operators say the re-

A demand-supply gap of 70% for key input S-PVC resin means MSME players making pipes have to depend on imports. China and other countries sell this input at low prices, hurting the market of big S-PVC producers. The DGFT order gives some protection to the big local input producers, but hurts MSMEs which have to budget for an immediate input price hike.

striction has already prompted major domestic manufacturers to raise the resin's prices. "Prices before the notification were Rs 78 per kg if you bought from a Chinese supplier. The domestic manufacturer was

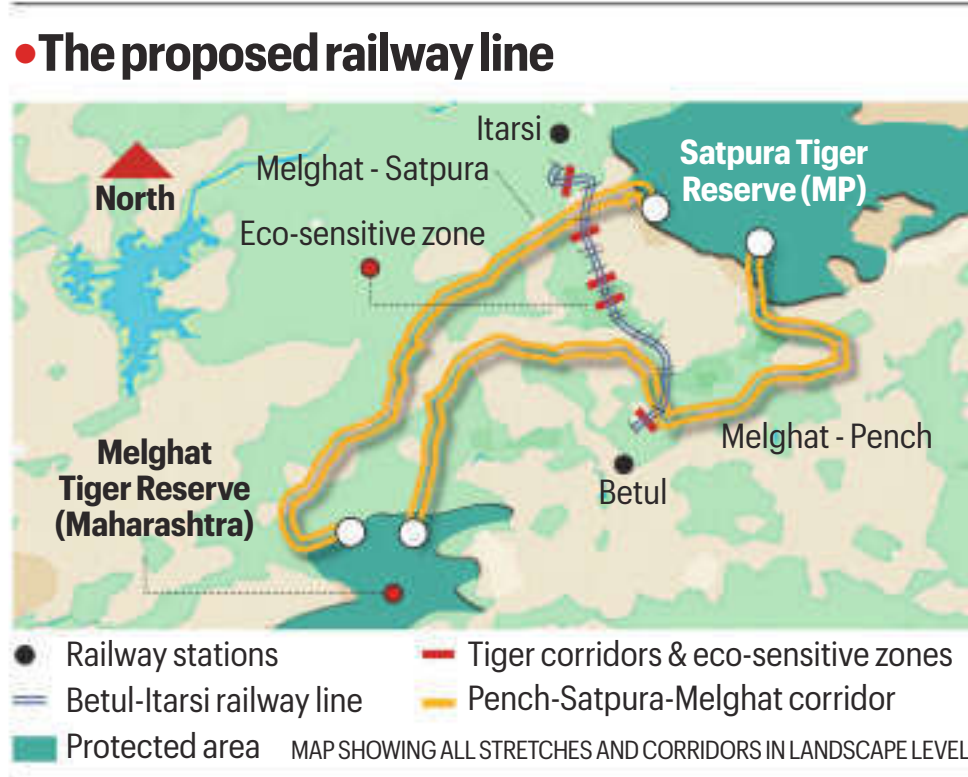
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Railway line through key tiger corridor gets in-principle approval, with a rider

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, August 1

CENTRAL INDIA'S key tiger corridor between the Satpura and Melghat tiger reserves stands to be fragmented because in-principle wildlife clearance for a third railway line between Jujharpur and Chichonda in Madhya Pradesh has been recommended by the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL).

The clearance is subject to the condition that mitigation structures — such as overpasses for safe passage of wildlife across the rail alignment — suggested by the Central Rail-



• The proposed railway line

way are reviewed and finalised based on proper scientific study and engineering designs, according to the minutes of the SC-NBWL's July 9 meeting.

The proposed railway line will pass through two notified tiger corridors, and an eco-sensitive zone in the Satpura-Melghat landscape, according to official documents. The Satpura tiger reserve is in Madhya Pradesh while the Melghat tiger reserve is in Maharashtra.

Tiger corridors provide safe pathways for many wildlife species including tigers, leopards, herbivores, sloth bears, helping the animals disperse to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• ALSO FIRST TO WIN MEDALS IN TWO DIFFERENT TRACK AND FIELD EVENTS AT COMMONWEALTH GAMES

With a strapped knee, Tejaswin becomes first Indian to win CWG decathlon medal

PAGE 1
anchor

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, August 1

"I WON'T cry today," Tejaswin Shankar said after becoming the first Indian decathlete to win a medal at the Commonwealth Games on Friday night.

Just four days ago, his CWG journey in Glasgow, Scotland, had almost ended in heartbreak before it even began when he pulled out of the individual high jump event due to patellar tendinitis, a painful injury commonly known as Jumper's knee.



Tejaswin Shankar competes in the decathlon long jump event at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Scotland. PTI

Yet, despite performing at '80 per cent' fitness, Tejaswin persevered over two days, winning a

bronze in decathlon, a grueling 10-event competition to determine the best all-round athlete

SPORT **PAGE 16**

**INDIAN BOXERS
SCRIPT GLORY
IN SCOTLAND**

in track and field, and even registering two personal bests in discus throw and long jump.

He is also the first Indian athlete to win medals in two different track and field events at the CWG. Four years ago in Birmingham, he won a bronze in high jump — it was also a first for India at the CWG — before becoming a multi-event athlete. He later won a silver in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Union Home Minister Amit Shah felicitates NSA Ajit Doval with the Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026 in Pune on Saturday. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Deputy CMs Sunetra Pawar and Eknath Shinde are also present. ANI

‘Big contribution in foreign policy’: Shah confers Lokmanya Tilak Award on Doval

Soham Shah
Pune, August 1

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah said on Friday that National Security Advisor Ajit Doval had played a big role in India’s foreign policy. Shah said this at the Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026 in Pune, where he presented the award to Doval. “Today, India’s foreign policy is one that has a spine. No one can deny this. With respect, we have strengthened our position in the world. And in this achievement of the Modi government, Ajit Doval has made a big contribution,” Shah said. Speaking about Lokmanya Tilak, Shah said that he gave a new direction to the Indian freedom struggle and laid a strong foundation for national-

ism, education, journalism, and social awakening. “His conviction continues to inspire every Indian today and serves as a guiding principle for building a developed and capable India,” he added. He said that Tilak’s message of “Swaraj is my birthright” should be transformed into a national resolve for a developed India in the present times. “Today those who talk of rights don’t know that if we misuse them, then the souls of those who sacrificed a lot for us to get these rights will likely be troubled,” he said. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Ministers Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar, and Pune MP and Union Minister Muralidhar Mohol were present at the event.

Mediation is key to accessible, dignified justice: CJI in Jaipur



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma in Jaipur. ROHIT JAIN PARAS

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 1

CHIEF JUSTICE of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Saturday made a strong case for mediation as an integral part of the justice delivery system, saying the rule of law seeks to ensure timely, accessible and dignified justice rather than adjudication of every dispute. Addressing the Commonwealth Peace Mediation Conference in Jaipur, the CJI said the justice system must prioritise outcomes that are efficient, humane and accessible to all. “The Rule of Law does not demand that every grievance be adjudicated, it demands only that every citizen enjoy timely, accessible, and dignified recourse to justice,” he said. Highlighting the advantages of mediation over adversarial processes, he emphasised the autonomy it gives to disputing parties in crafting their own solutions. “Mediation alone permits the parties themselves to

author their own resolution, addressing the true sources of conflict at a pace and cost proportionate to the dispute. He noted that mediation enables a shift away from rigid legal positions towards a more meaningful resolution of disputes, especially in situations where preserving relationships is important. The also underscored the broader philosophical and practical relevance of mediation, suggesting that such approaches align with both modern needs and longstanding traditions of dispute resolution. He expressed confidence that mediation would continue to grow in importance as legal systems evolve to handle increasing caseloads and complex disputes. Referring to the enduring relevance of such mechanisms, he said they represent “a tradition as old as our ancient heritage and as urgent as Monday morning’s docket”. The CJI concluded his address on a note of optimism, extending his best wishes for the success of the conference.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Small firms that make PVC pipes

selling it at around Rs 82 per kg. As soon as the notification came, the domestic manufacturer hiked the prices to Rs 93 per kg,” said Sharwan Kumar Kaler, Director at Rex Pipe and Cable Industries Ltd, and Vice President, Plastic Manufacturing Association, Rajasthan. The impact is widespread. India’s PVC capacity is just 1.7 million metric tonnes (MMT) against demand of 4.7 MMT, a gap filled by imports from China, Japan, Taiwan, South Korea, Mexico and Indonesia. Reliance Industries is the largest domestic producer, accounting for 51% of capacity. Other players—Chemplast Sanmar, Finolex Industries, DCW Ltd and DCM Shriram—together hold 5-20%, according to rating agency ICRA. “The material is already in short supply. Now, with the government taking such steps, domestic industries will feel the pain, and prices will rise in the consumer market. If raw material prices go up, finished goods prices will follow,” said Ajay Saboo, Executive Committee Member of the Federation of Indian Micro and Small & Medium Enterprises (FISME). Demand for PVC resin grew at a CAGR of 6.2% between FY20 and FY25. In 2024-25, demand rose 11%, driven by government housing and water-supply schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana and Jal Jeevan Mission. Meanwhile, the Adani Group has announced plans to enter the sector, setting up a PVC plant in Mundra, Gujarat, through its subsidiary Mundra Petrochem Limited. The project began in 2021, but major equipment procurement and site construction were put on hold in 2023. Work on the Mundra project resumed in 2024, with an initial planned capacity of 1 million tonnes per annum, and commissioning expected by fiscal 2028. Reliance Industries currently makes PVC via the oil-derived ethylene route and plans to expand capacity to 1.5 MMT per annum by 2026-27. Adani Group, by contrast, is building a 2 MMT integrated PVC complex at Mundra using the coal-to-chemical (calcium carbide) route, with the first 1 MMT phase expected to start production in FY 2027-28. If Adani enters the PVC resin business, it would mark the first major petrochemical product in which Reliance and Adani compete directly in the Indian market. Industry experts say coal-based PVC production is cheaper because its economics are largely insulated from crude oil price swings. Queries emailed to the Commerce and Industry Ministry, Adani Group and Reliance Industries (RIL) remained unanswered. The DGFT notification sets a Minimum Import Price (MIP): S-PVC priced above \$0.766/kg remains freely importable for six months, while anything below that is restricted (barring Export Oriented Units, SEZs and the Advance Authorisation Scheme). This shuts out the cheapest suppliers—major exporters’ prices are in the \$0.65-0.75/kg range, with China’s the lowest, according to a Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) report. Chemical sector advisor Ajay Joshi linked the dumping to two factors: nearly 70% of China’s PVC production uses the coal-based route, insulating it from oil and gas prices, and a domestic real estate slump has weakened Chinese demand. “With housing projects slowing, demand for pipes, plastic products, and consequently, PVC has weakened significantly. As a result, Chinese producers have been dumping excess material into India, driving PVC prices down to around \$700 per tonne,” Joshi said. ICRA had flagged similar dumping from China, Indonesia, Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, Thailand and the US, last year. DCM Shriram defended the MIP as a floor, not a price-setter: “It only blocks distress-priced cargo from treating India as a dumping ground for their excess capacities... PVC resin is a small fraction of total project costs, and a six-month floor price cannot materially move project economics. The distress from dumping of PVC that the MIP addresses is real and well documented,” the company said. The DGTR’s MIP follows an earlier investigation last year after which anti-dumping duties ranging from \$22 to \$284 per tonne were recommended on August 14, 2025, on imports from China, Japan, Taiwan, South Korea, Thailand, Indonesia and the United States. Under Rule 18 of the Customs Tariff (Identification, Assessment and Collection of Anti-Dumping Duty on Dumped Articles and for Determination of Injury) Rules, 1995, the Ministry of Finance had three months to impose the duty through a customs notification. As no notification was issued by mid-November 2025, the DGTR recommendation lapsed.

Rail line through key tiger corridor gets nod

newer landscape and aiding genetic flow of wildlife. A committee that inspected the alignment sites noted in its report to the SC-NBWL that the forest stretch and corridors are a lifeline for the Satpura-Pench-Melghat landscape, and hence the project should be seen in the context of current and future perspectives. The 160.6-km stretch between Juiharpur (Betul district) and Natchonda (Narmadapuram district), forms part of a longer 290-km third and fourth railway line on the busy Itarsi-Nagpur route, proposed by the Central Railway, Mumbai headquarters. The alignment passes through forest areas, two notified tiger corridors and an eco-sensitive zone. The project requires use of 206.09 hectares of land – 74.69 hectares of forest land and 131.4 hectares of non-forest land – falling in the notified tiger corridor. The proposal was earlier considered by the SC-NBWL at its 88th meeting on January 19. A final decision, though, was deferred as a site inspection was deemed necessary. The site inspection was carried out by officials from the Railways, Union Environment Ministry, a scientist from the Wildlife Institute of India, and an official from the National Tiger Conservation Authority. The site inspection committee’s report stated that the Central Railway had proposed 34 wildlife overpasses along the rail line alignment. However, they were largely based on inputs from frontline forest staff, wildlife mortality records, rather than a detailed scientific study. The SC-NBWL’s July 9 meeting minutes also noted that detailed engineering designs of these structures were yet to be finalised. “It was further observed that a comprehensive scientific assessment of the likely impacts of the project and the appropriate landscape-level mitigation measures had not been completed at the time of inspection. The State Forest Research Institute, Jabalpur, had been entrusted with the study, and its report was awaited,” the minutes noted. Given the lack of a comprehensive study, the site inspection committee said that optimal, landscape-level mitigation measures were required, particularly considering that the Itarsi-Nagpur line expansion includes construction of a third as well as possibly a fourth line. The Chief Wildlife Warden of Madhya Pradesh informed the wildlife board panel that the state forest research institute had submitted a detailed report on mitigation measures and it was under consideration, and assured it would form the basis for overpass designs. The SC-NBWL also directed that upon receipt and examination of the scientific study and other relevant data, the site inspection committee shall revisit the project area and submit definitive recommendations regarding the location, dimensions, design and connectivity of the wildlife mitigation structures.

First Indian to win CWG decathlon medal

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mliMzgj decathlon at the Asian Games and a silver and a bronze at the Asian Championships, leaving only a CWG medal in this intense event missing from his collection. “Today, I am standing with a medal around my neck, I have no words. This is just unreal,” Tejaswin said after winning the bronze Friday. “When I was standing there crying (after pulling out of high jump), those were tears of giving up. I was thinking one year is gone, the Commonwealth Games are gone, maybe the Asian Games are gone too. I went down a very negative spiral.” Given the circumstances—a knee injury and a strong field, including the Tokyo Olympic champion Damien Warner of Canada and Paris Olympics bronze medallist and reigning CWG champion Lindon Victor of Grenada—Tejaswin’s 7,976 points for third place was a gritty performance. Victor got the gold with 8,096 points and Warner the silver with 8,036 points. A fully fit Tejaswin could have changed the colour of his medal given that his national record is 8,057 points. Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mliMzgj

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mliMzgj Despite the injury setback, however, Tejaswin’s comeback was a tale of remarkable resilience, with his support staff doing all to get him up and running. His strength and conditioning coach Wayne Lombard was in Glasgow and played a key role in Tejaswin’s recovery, ensuring he didn’t lose heart when the going got tough. Indian team doctor Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala, an orthopedic surgeon, kept a close watch on Tejaswin’s knee and prescribed anti-inflammatory medicines. “I would say it’s the performance of the Commonwealth Games. To win a decathlon medal with 80% fitness tells you what it takes to be an elite-level athlete,” Lombard told The Indian Express Saturday. “Tejaswin had thought that he had let everyone down. I haven’t seen him this disappointed ever. We threw everything we had to make sure that he is ready by the time the decathlon starts,” said Wayne. For Tejaswin’s decathlon, Wayne said the team “wanted to keep the strain on the knee as low as possible.” “We wanted to make sure that the discomfort and the pain he was feeling was not too significant. So, between the anti-inflammatories, a lot of icing, and then a lot of rehab, we did a few micro-dosed rehab sessions,” he said. Moral support came from long jumper Sreesankar Murali. “When I went back completely broken, the one person who came up to me was Sreesankar. He had the same injury but a lot worse than mine. He told me to just take one event at a time,” Tejaswin said. The competition was a mix of ups and downs for the decathlete. After barely making it to the 100m race with a heavily strapped knee, he clocked 10.96s and earned 870 points, placing him at the seventh spot. He fought back with a personal best in the second event, the long jump. He jumped 7.82 metres to improve on his previous best of 7.67m and moved to second spot with 1,015 points. After shot put, high jump and the 400-metre race at the end of Day 1, he was second with 4,339 points behind Warner, who had 4,353 points. “When he ended Day 1, all we wanted was proper recovery for him. Thankfully, his knee was not much flared up. I told him that you have a medal shot, just let your body rest,” said Wayne. Day 2 has always been more challenging for Tejaswin as it involves some of his weaker events, discus throw and pole vault. He threw a lifetime best of 40.44 metres in discus to stay second. However, despite a decent 4.30 metres, he was eighth in pole vault. But when it mattered the most, he fought back with 53.21 metres in javelin and clocked 4:36.19 to finish fifth in the 1,500-metre run. The last two events earned him 1,339 points, enough to better Ball by 83 points to win bronze. When asked why he decided to compete in both high jump and the decathlon, Tejaswin said, “Yeh dil maange more. High jump is good, but when you can do more, why not.”

REGISTRATION PORTAL LAUNCHED

Women need endorsement letter from MP or MLA to avail Rs 2,500 monthly aid

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 1

WOMEN APPLYING for the Rekha Gupta government's flagship Delhi Lakshmi Yojana will have to submit an endorsement letter from the MP or MLA of their constituency, according to fresh eligibility conditions unveiled in the scheme's registration portal that was launched on Saturday.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched the portal at the East Delhi District Magistrate's office. Under the scheme, eligible women will receive Rs 2,500 every month.

Speaking at the launch, Gupta said every application would undergo a four-stage verification process to ensure that "only genuine beneficiaries" receive assistance.

Applications will first be scrutinised by the District Programme Management Unit, followed by verification by the District Women and Child Development Officer, before being placed before the District-Level Approval, Monitoring and Grievance Redressal Committee for a final nod.

The CM said the verification process would include Aadhaar authentication, Delhi voter registration, annual family income, family details, electricity consumption, vehicle ownership, pension status and government service records. She said false declarations or fraudulent claims would invite recovery of the financial assistance along with legal and administrative action.

Within hours of the portal going live, officials said more than 33,700 women had regis-



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the launch of the portal on Saturday. X/@GUPTA_REKHA

tered. Among them, 1,940 had completed the application process, while another 9,170 applications were awaiting MLA recommendations, they added.

The scheme, approved for an initial period of three years, is expected to cover nearly 17 lakh women. Beneficiaries can either receive Rs 1,000 in a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) wallet and Rs 1,500 in a recurring deposit (RD) or fixed deposit (FD) account every month, or choose to have the entire Rs 2,500 deposited into an RD or FD for long-term savings.

The government has also placed spending restrictions on the CBDC wallet. Money credited to the wallet cannot be used to purchase alcohol, to-

bacco, narcotic substances, lottery tickets, gambling or betting services, or other prohibited goods and services.

Among one of the major eligibility conditions imposed is a three-child cap – an exclusion criterion that is uncommon among major social welfare schemes in Delhi.

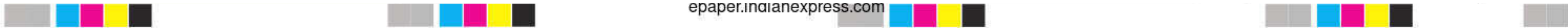
It has drawn criticism from Opposition parties and civil society groups.

The other conditions are applicants must be the eldest eligible woman in the family, aged between 21 and 60 years, belong to a household with an annual income of not more than Rs 2.5 lakh, have at least 10 years' residence in Delhi, their parents or husband, be regis-

tered voters in the Capital. Also, a recent electricity meter reading has to be submitted to establish that their household's annual power consumption does not exceed 2,400 units.

Further, the scheme excludes families in which any member is a regular or contractual employee of the Union or Delhi government, public sector undertakings or local bodies. Households in which any member pays income tax or is a registered GST filer are also ineligible. Those already receiving financial assistance, including widow, retirement or disability pensions, cannot avail the benefits to prevent overlap with existing welfare schemes.

Even the Indian Embassy in Hungary, which also serves the neighbouring Bosnia and Herzegovina, has a built-in 'Bharati' chatbot on its website. The emphasis now is to channelise these platforms to multiply outreach, and also make their messaging more visual and interesting than just replying to standard text.



‘Rs 1,800 cr loss to EPFO’: CBI books Anil Ambani

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 1

THE CBI has registered an FIR against Reliance Capital Limited (RCL) and its former chairman Anil Ambani for allegedly causing a loss of Rs 1,816.22 crore to the Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO).

Ambani, however, denied any wrongdoing, according to a statement issued by his spokesperson.

“The CBI has registered a FIR on July 31 on the basis of a written complaint received from the EPFO, Ministry of Labour and Employment, against M/s Reliance Capital Limited, Mumbai, Anil D. Ambani, its former Chairman, unknown public servants and other unknown persons for allegedly causing a wrongful loss of Rs 1,007.55 crore, along with an interest liability of Rs 808.67 crore, by committing offences including criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust and criminal misconduct,” a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

“It has been alleged in the complaint that, during 2013 and

2014, RCL issued secured Non-Convertible Debentures (NCDs), in which the EPFO invested Rs 2,500 crore through four portfolio managers including Reliance Capital Asset Management Limited. The NCDs were due to mature during 2023 and 2024,” the spokesperson alleged.

“It is further alleged that the accused persons indulged in fraudulent transactions and diversion of funds, resulting in the default in redemption of the NCDs by Reliance Capital Limited and causing a total alleged loss of Rs 1,816.22 crore to the EPFO,” the spokesperson alleged.

Responding to the complaint, Ambani’s spokesperson said, “The FIR registered by the CBI pertains to Reliance Capital Limited. Mr Ambani served as a Non-Executive Director/Chairman of the Board of Reliance Capital Limited from 2005 until November 2021, when the Reserve Bank of India superseded the Board of Directors of the company and appointed an administrator. Anil Ambani denies any wrongdoing, whatsoever, and reserves all rights available to him in law.”

The Ministry of Labour and Employment sent the complaint after it was intimidated by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) that it had found documentary evidence and a transaction audit conducted by BDO India LLP that showed prima facie a number of fraudulent transactions by RCL and the persons in charge of its management during the period from December 7, 2019 to December 6, 2021. During an earlier period too, various fraudulent transactions were found which led to the ultimate failure of RCL “as a consequence of siphoning off of money of RCL”, the complaint alleged.

According to the FIR, the ED probe prima facie indicated a series of transactions involving irregular lending, diversion of funds, impairment of security and other acts by RCL that required investigation. “If established upon investigation, such conduct may have materially contributed to the financial deterioration of RCL, its inability to honour its obligation towards Debenture Holders, and the consequent loss of Rs 1,816.22 crore suffered by EPFO,” the complaint alleged.

SC judge says calling people ‘ants’ or other names unconstitutional

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan calls for greater transparency in judicial appointments

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 1

SUPREME COURT judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said on Saturday that the lack of transparency in judicial appointments could allow people to enter the judiciary who later go on to describe a group of people as “ants” and “get away with it,” calling such remarks “completely unconstitutional”.

Urging greater public scrutiny of those being considered for judgeship, Justice Bhuyan said, “To prevent entry of such people, there should be discussion, there should be some reasons given. What harm is caused if there is some discussion in the public about that these are the people who will be

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Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

judges in our country?”

Justice Bhuyan made the remarks while speaking at an event at IIC New Delhi organised by the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy for the release of a report titled “The Judicial Transparency Index”.

The report looked at how much information the Supreme Court and the 25 high courts make publicly available, including on court proceedings, administration and judicial appointments. It noted that while recent Collegium resolutions on appointments and transfers are available online, many do not give reasons for the recommendations.

Flagging what he described as the opacity surrounding the Collegium system, Justice Bhuyan said deliberations over the elevation and transfer of judges remain confidential, and reasons for rejecting or deferring recommendations are rarely disclosed in full.

He also questioned the absence of reasons in three Supreme Court Collegium resolutions from 2025, contrasting these with earlier resolutions where he said recommendations were supported by reasons.

He said the principle underlying open courts and the public’s right to know should also extend to information about those appointed as judges. “Citizens... have a right to know what is happening in the court. They have a right to know who would be their judges. They have a right to know what kind of judgments the honourable judge has delivered. This should be in the public domain,” he said.

Justice Bhuyan also referred to the SC Collegium’s January 18, 2023, resolution reiterating its recommendation to

appoint Senior Advocate Saurabh Kirpal as a judge of the Delhi High Court as an example where detailed reasons had been given. However, that recommendation had remained pending for over three years.

Referring to the Constitution Bench judgment that brought the office of the Chief Justice of India within the ambit of the Right to Information Act, he emphasised the relationship between judicial independence and accountability, quoting the court’s observation that “judicial independence cannot be used as a byword for avoiding accountability.”

While courts had made significant advances in transparency in their adjudicatory functions, including through live-streaming, Justice Bhuyan said the same openness had not necessarily extended to the judiciary’s own institutional processes.

He said that “a judiciary that has embraced publicity in its adjudicative function has been markedly more cautious about extending the same principle to its own constitutive process.”

No junk food within 50 metres of schools and colleges: New Karnataka advisory

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 1

THE KARNATAKA Food Safety and Drug Administration (FSDA) department has issued an advisory restricting the sale of food products high in fat, sugar, and salt within a 50-metre radius of schools and colleges in the state. The advisory comes in the wake of FSDA inspections of food business establishments located around 134 schools and colleges in July.

“During the inspections, the quality of food products, hygiene and sanitation, compliance with food safety standards, labelling requirements, sale of expired food products

and validity of licences/registrations of Food Business Operators were verified... it was observed that certain food business establishments located within and around school and college premises were selling high fat, sugar and salt food products,” the FSDA said in a statement Friday.

Based on the findings, an advisory was issued on July 24 that sale of such products within 50 metres of school and college premises be discouraged, healthy food choices should be promoted, and food business operators strictly comply with the food safety regulations.

“District designated officers and food safety officers have been instructed to effectively

implement the advisory across the state and to create awareness among school and college managements, food business operators and the general public,” the FSDA said.

The department directed all food establishments located near schools to be licensed and registered under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006. It also said that food safety officers would conduct regular inspections around schools, colleges.

Violation of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 and the Food Safety and Standards Rules/Regulations, 2011 will result in “issuance of improvement notices, suspension or cancellation of licence, seizure

of food products, and judicial proceedings, wherever necessary”, it added.

The advisory recommended that school meals be designed as cereal-protein combinations rich in micronutrients. It said menus should include whole grains, pulses, millets, and animal-based foods such as milk and eggs, and use fresh, seasonal, and locally available produce. To make the meals more nutritious, “fortified wheat flour, rice, milk, edible oil and double fortified salt may be used strictly adhering to the standards specified in the Food Safety and Standards (Fortification of Foods) Regulations, 2018”, the advisory further said.

AFTER SUPREME COURT ORDER

Gujarat DGP sets up SIT to probe ‘custodial death’ of 70-year-old

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, August 1

THE GUJARAT Police has constituted a three-member special investigation team (SIT) to probe the alleged custodial death of 70-year-old Zahiruddin Shaikh at Ahmedabad’s Vejalpur police station, days after the Supreme Court directed the registration of an FIR and ordered an independent probe.

The SIT has been constituted by Gujarat Director General of Police G S Malik in compliance with the SCs July 23 order. The team will be headed by SP (CID Crime) Rohan Anand and comprise CID Crime Deputy SP P D Vala and CID Crime Police Inspector NH Siddiqui.

In a communication to the Ahmedabad police commissioner, the DGP has directed that an FIR be registered on charges of murder and abetment of suicide, in accordance with the Supreme Court order. The SIT was constituted following a July 23 SC order by a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana. The bench observed that there was a prima facie case for registration of an FIR after considering the submissions made by Senior Advocate I H Syed, appearing for the petitioner’s family.

“We are satisfied that a prima facie case for registration of an FIR under Sections 103 and 108 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, without naming any suspects at this stage, is made out. Consequently, the said FIR shall be investigated by an Special Investigation Team, comprising of a police officer of the rank of deputy commissioner of police

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along with two more officers, to be nominated by the director general of police, Gujarat...”, the order states.

The SC order further directed, “The members of the SIT must be those who are not posted in the district where the alleged occurrence took place. The SIT is directed to file the final report after investigation before the jurisdictional magistrate as early as possible, and preferably within two months.”

The SC’s intervention came on an appeal filed by Zahiruddin Shaikh’s son, Tofik, challenging the failure of the authorities to register a criminal case over his father’s death after he was taken into custody by the Vejalpur police. Shaikh was arrested on May 18 in connection with an alleged cow slaughter case registered by the Vejalpur police. His family has alleged in their petition that police personnel forcibly administered 30 to 40 tablets of prescription medicines to Shaikh, resulting in a fatal overdose on May 20.

The SC’s directions came nearly two months after the Gujarat HC declined to order registration of an FIR, holding that the petitioner must first exhaust the statutory remedies available under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita. Even while dismissing the petition on May 29, the HC had observed that it was “ironic” that an alleged violation of the SC’s Constitution bench judgment in Lalita Kumari vs Government of UP on mandatory registration of FIRs in cognisable offences could not be directly enforced through a writ petition because of the doctrine of alternative statutory remedy.

Santiago to Shopian and Delhi — pellet guns in crowd control



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY MURARI

ON JULY 30, inside the Supreme Court, legal arguments clashed with a physical tragedy. At the heart of the debate were Sahil Lochab, a 19-year-old student fighting to save his eye after a metal pellet tore into it, and Irshad Sheikh, a young worker who underwent surgery for embedded pellets.

The court refused an outright ban, noting exceptional situations, but left the door open for an inquiry. Yet, a chilling question hung in the air. How did a shotgun, used for years in conflict zones, end up being fired at unarmed students in the heart of Delhi?

To understand how we got here, we must look at the history of pellet guns and their use in crowd control. Using them on civilian crowds is a modern nightmare born from an attempt to be 'merciful'. The blueprint was drawn in 1950s' Hong Kong. Following the bloody Double Ten riots, colonial police fired wooden baton rounds, or projectiles made of wood, to control violent mobs. The British military improvised further during The Troubles in Northern Ireland. In 1970, facing Catholic civil rights protests, soldiers fired rubber and later, plastic bullets. Fired at close range, they shattered bones and skulls. A 10-year-old boy in Derry was completely blinded, and 17 people were killed. Pellet-firing shotguns followed, causing immediate, severe facial injuries.

The weapon travelled the world, almost always finding the fragile human eye. During the First Intifada between 1987 and 1993, the Israeli military fired rubber and plastic rounds directly at Palestinian protesters, starting decades of life-altering eye injuries affecting children. This approach to riot control eventually found its way to Europe. In France, during Yellow Vest protests over



During the Cockroach Janta Party protests at Connaught Place. GAJENDRA YADAV

economic inequality, police fired heavy rubber-pellet launchers at crowds, leaving protesters with torn ears, shattered jaws, brain trauma, and irreversible eye damage.

During Chile's 2019 civil unrest over inequality, health agencies recorded up to 445 cases of severe eye trauma. Anger boiled over when a university study proved the supposedly rubber pellets were actually 80% heavy metals. Forced into a corner by blinded citizens, Chile's military police chief finally suspended their use. Following racial justice protests in 2020, 19 American cities agreed to pay 80 million dollars in settlements to maimed people. Meanwhile, during protests in Iran, shotguns became tools of mass blinding. On January 9 and 10 alone, a Tehran hospital reported nearly a 1,000 patients arriving for ruptured eyeballs, with scans from Mashhad showing metal pellets lodged deep inside eyes.

For years, the police fired these weapons into crowds with no clear international rules. The United Nations finally stepped in with the UN Human Rights Office releasing in 2020 its first-ever comprehensive guidance on less-lethal weapons to fill this void. They realised that governments were deploying these weapons with zero global standards on their design, test-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 ing, or use. When it came to metal shotgun pellets, the UN was absolute: they should never be used for crowd control. Because they scatter wildly, it is physically impossible to aim them safely, making them inherently indiscriminate.

India too has a documented history of deploying pellet guns. The pump-action shotguns used by paramilitary forces are made at Rifle Factory Ishapore in Ichhapur, West Bengal. A single cartridge shoots hundreds of high-velocity metal pellets that scatter wildly. Beyond Kashmir, the weapon has surfaced in other civilian protests. During the 2024 farmers' protests along the Punjab-Haryana border, farm leaders alleged several protesters were injured by pellets, though police firmly denied using them. Similarly, allegations of pellet gun usage during the late 2025 unrest in Ladakh were met with official denials. The weapons were also reportedly used during ethnic violence in Manipur.

At least 2,524 people were injured by pellets, many in the eyes, in eight of the 10 districts in the Kashmir valley during the crackdown on protests that followed the killing of militant Burhan Wani on July 8 last year, according to data compiled from official records by the J&K government for the State Human Rights Commission (SHRC) in 2017.

During that 2016 unrest, schoolgirl Insha Mushtaq was hit by pellets while standing by her window, losing her sight completely. Ten years later, the government finally released funds to help her run a gas agency.

Following the 2016 outcry over Kashmir, the Union Home Ministry formed a committee, deciding that forces must first use chilli shells and stun grenades, keeping pellet guns as a final resort.

Governments worldwide often reach for these weapons hoping to control crowds without killing. But as courts argue over police manuals, for many young people with pellet injuries --- from Santiago to Shopian to New Delhi --- the reality on the ground remains unchanged.

The writer is Senior Assistant Editor, Indian Express Hindi

67 BODIES RECOVERED

Spain installs floating barrier in Ceuta after deadly migrant rush

EU governments call for emergency meeting on border security

Michael Francis Gore
Ceuta, August 1

SPAIN SAID migrant crossings into its North African enclave of Ceuta had stopped overnight, as police began installing a 500-metre floating barrier on Saturday off its border with Morocco following a mass rush that killed at least 67 people.

According to Spanish authorities, about 50,000 people had crossed into Ceuta by land and sea from Thursday in an unprecedented surge at one of the EU's only land borders with Africa. More than 48,000 of them returned to Morocco within 48 hours without major incident, Spain said.

Reuters footage on Saturday showed Spanish soldiers and police patrolling a mostly empty Tarajal beach shrouded in fog. Civil Guard police started laying the new barrier at 7:50 a.m. (0550 GMT) on the Tarajal breakwater, one of the main points used by people trying to enter the tiny Spanish



Spanish soldiers rescue an injured migrant on the beach in Ceuta on Saturday. REUTERS

territory, the government said in a statement.

The pneumatic barrier, alongside a line of anchored naval buoys, is designed to stand 30 to 70 centimetres (12 to 28 inches) above water and extend as much as one metre below the surface, it added, while a channel between the barriers will allow Civil Guard vessels to patrol the area.

At least 67 bodies have been recovered on the Spanish side

of the frontier, officials said, after some migrants drowned and others were crushed while trying to climb the breakwater and border fence. Many were driven to migrate by economic hardship and encouraged by social media rumours.

Spanish Interior Minister Fernando Grande-Marlaska blamed people-smuggling networks for exploiting vulnerable migrants and spreading misleading interpretations of a re-

cent Spanish Supreme Court ruling that migrants intercepted at sea cannot be summarily returned in the absence of a physical barrier.

Speaking from Ceuta, Grande-Marlaska told reporters Spain had largely restored order within 24 hours, but warned that the crisis was not yet formally over and that reinforced police and military deployments would remain as long as needed, though over-

night crossings had fallen to about zero.

"Morocco isn't any threat to Ceuta or the rest of Spain — it's a fully reliable partner," he said, adding there had been no intelligence indicating a mass entry was imminent.

Ceuta and Spain's other North African enclave, Melilla, sit on Morocco's Mediterranean coast and periodically face attempted crossings by migrants seeking to reach Europe.

The latest attempt caused division in the EU, with several countries calling for Spain to ensure that the incident was contained.

Twenty-two EU governments called on Saturday for an emergency meeting of interior ministers over the Ceuta crisis, urging the bloc to help Madrid regain control of its border with Morocco. Meanwhile, Spain's centre-left Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez also asked EU leaders to convene interior ministers urgently, but criticised governments that had called for Spain's exclusion from the bloc's passport-free Schengen travel area.

Madrid said the people who entered Ceuta irregularly could not travel onwards to mainland Spain or elsewhere in the Schengen zone. REUTERS

China issues new rules to assert its control over South China Sea shoal

Press Trust of India
Beijing, August 1

CHINA ON Saturday issued management measures for the Huangyan Dao National Nature Reserve in the disputed South China Sea, a move likely to further escalate its maritime row with the Philippines, which has counterclaims over the shoal.

The measures are a key step in safeguarding the diversity, stability and sustainability of the Huangyan Dao natural ecosystem, an official announcement said here tonight.

Under the rules, a routine patrol system will be established to promptly investigate and handle violations in accordance with the law.



Under the rules, a routine patrol system will be established. FILE

Violators will be held accountable under relevant laws and regulations, state-run Xinhua news agency quoted the rules jointly issued by the Ministry of Natural Resources, the National Forestry and Grassland Administration, the China Coast Guard, and the Hainan provincial government.

Without prior approval, any activities such as fishing, mining, and the extraction of corals, coral reefs or giant clams that damage rare marine species and the natural ecosystem are prohibited, it said.

No individual or organisation may enter the reserve, except as otherwise provided by laws and regulations or for activities organised for conservation and management purposes, it said.

Earlier, the PLA Southern Theatre Command (STC) conducted a joint naval-air training exercise focusing on multiple realistic training subjects in the territorial sea and airspace of Huangyan Dao and its surrounding areas on Saturday, the Chinese military said.

Gor calls on Bangladesh to join Pax Silica initiative

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, August 1

US SPECIAL Envoy for South and Central Asia Sergio Gor on Saturday discussed bilateral ties, trade and investment with Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman and called on Dhaka to join the US-led Pax Silica initiative, local media reported.

In a meeting with PM Rahman at his office in Tejgaon here, Gor said that Bangladesh has significant potential to become a partner in the global economic security alliance focused on critical minerals, energy, semiconductors, and AI infrastructure, the Dhaka Tribune newspaper reported, citing the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Pax Silica, led by the US

State Department, aimed to reduce reliance on Chinese tech dominance.

The two sides also discussed bilateral relations, trade and investment, regional cooperation and other issues of mutual interest during the meeting, state-owned Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha (BSS) quoted PM's Deputy Press Secretary Shahadat Shadhin as saying.

"Today I called on the Honourable PM @trahmanbnp to discuss the great opportunities between the US and Bangladesh to strengthen economic cooperation and enhance our partnership. This is a priority for the US, and working together we can achieve real results," Gor, who is also US Ambassador to India, posted on X after the meeting.

FCNR(B) DEPOSITS HAD LARGEST SHARE AT \$36.725 BILLION

RBI's swap window draws \$40.8 bn forex inflows under 2 mths



George Mathew
Mumbai, August 1

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) concessional swap facility has attracted foreign exchange inflows worth over \$40 billion in less than two months, reflecting strong overseas investor and depositor response to the central bank's liquidity-enhancing measure.

The RBI on Saturday said total inflows mobilised under the special facility stood at \$40.816 billion as on July 31, 2026. Of this, Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) — FCNR(B) — deposits accounted for the largest share at \$36.725 billion, followed by Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) at \$2.575 billion and External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) at \$1.516 billion.

The central bank had announced the concessional swap facility on June 5, 2026, to encourage fresh foreign currency inflows and support domestic liquidity. The scheme became operational on June 8, 2026. Under the facility, the RBI offers concessional swap arrangements for fresh FCNR(B) deposits mobilised by banks as well as eligible OFCB and ECB inflows.

The swap window for

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Record July dispatches by Coal India as reliance on thermal power rises

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 1

INDIA'S LARGEST coal miner, Coal India Ltd (CIL), reported an 8.44% year-on-year increase in coal production to 50.36 million tonnes (MT) in July, while coal dispatches surged 18.38% to 64.19 MT, driven by higher demand from the power sector.

"The coal supplied in July FY27 (financial year 2027) marks the highest-ever coal off-take for the month of July in any financial year.

"The previous highest July supply stood at 60.5 MT, achieved in FY25," the state-owned miner said in a stock exchange filing on Saturday.

CIL's cumulative coal supplies during the first four months of FY27 (April-July) also touched a record high of

262.04 MT, up 6.9% year-on-year, surpassing the previous best of 259.4 MT recorded during the corresponding period of FY25. Supplies to the power sector, the company's largest consumer segment, rose 18% to 49.77 MT in July from 42.35 MT a year earlier.

The sharp rise in coal production and dispatches comes as below-normal monsoon rainfall has increased the power system's reliance on coal-fired generation amid a decline in hydroelectric output.

The southwest monsoon, which lasts until September, has been affected by an intensifying El Niño, resulting in drier-than-normal conditions across large parts of the country. Although rainfall improved in July after a significantly dry June, the recovery

has been insufficient to erase the seasonal deficit, with cumulative rainfall still about 13% below normal.

The weak monsoon has also kept electricity demand elevated, pushing the country's peak power demand to 270 gigawatts (GW) in July.

The rainfall deficit has significantly squeezed hydro-power generation, increasing the country's dependence on coal-fired electricity. Coal-based power generation rose 9.49% on-year to 463,995.61 MU during April 1-July 30, 2026, from 423,764.78 MU a year earlier. The reliance on coal-based power was even more pronounced during July, with coal-fired generation rising 13.08% year-on-year.

been restrained from accessing the securities market for two months. In its final order issued on Friday, SEBI held that land parcels owned by ZEEL in Hyderabad were used as collateral for loans availed by Essel Group entities without the knowledge or approval of the company's board of directors or audit committee.

The transactions were also not disclosed to shareholders or investors, constituting a serious breach of corporate governance and fiduciary responsibilities. The violations relate to transactions carried out in 2018. Privately held firms of the promoter group had taken a loan from the lenders. When

• DRAWING CAPITAL

FCNR (B) DEPOSITS are fixed-term bank deposits that can be opened in India by NRIs, Overseas Citizens of India and Persons of Indian Origin

THESE DEPOSITS allow overseas Indians to maintain their savings in designated foreign currencies such as the US dollar, pound sterling or euro, rather than converting their funds into Indian rupees

THE SCHEME was introduced to stabilise the rupee and foreign exchange reserves of the country which came under pressure due to the West Asia conflict and rise in crude oil prices

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FCNR(B) deposits will remain open until September 30, 2026, while the facility for OFCBs and ECBs will continue until December 31, 2026. FCNR(B) deposits are fixed-term bank deposits that can be opened in India by NRIs, Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs) and Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs).

These deposits allow overseas Indians to maintain their savings in designated foreign currencies such as the US dollar, pound sterling, euro, Japanese yen, Australian dollar and Canadian dollar, rather than converting their funds into Indian rupees.

Interest earned on FCNR(B) deposits is exempt from income tax in India as long as the depositor qualifies as a non-resident under Indian tax laws. Under the current framework, banks can offer rates linked to internationally accepted benchmark rates.

With two months to go for the scheme's closure, experts are expecting \$70-80 billion in inflows. The scheme was introduced to stabilise the rupee and foreign exchange reserves of the country which came under pressure due to the West Asia conflict and rise in crude oil prices. The overwhelming contribution from FCNR(B) de-

posits indicates strong participation by non-resident Indians, helping banks mobilise long-term foreign currency resources at a time when the RBI is seeking to bolster foreign exchange liquidity.

According to an UBS report, over the past week, some investors have questioned the validity of these inflow estimates, given that they are not yet fully reflected in the RBI's reported foreign currency assets (FCA), banking system liquidity conditions, or bank deposit growth data. "The RBI has explicitly stated that the scheme applies to fresh FCNR(B) deposits, including deposits renewed upon maturity, implying that a part of the reported mobilisation may reflect the rollover of existing FCNR(B) deposits under more attractive terms," UBS said. "We believe the RBI also likely absorbed part of these inflows to unwind portions of its sizeable forward forex book (which stood at \$106.7 billion as of end May), particularly at shorter maturities. Since June 5, foreign currency assets (FCA) have increased by \$7.6 billion through July 17, while bank deposit growth has remained relatively modest at 12.7% year-on-year in the fortnight ended July 15, 2026," it said.

By 2080, Bangladesh's capital will be losing the equivalent of 1.65 million jobs annually due to 7.4% of working hours becoming unworkable due to heat stress.

The number of equivalent jobs lost in India's four metros — New Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata — will more than double to 2 million.

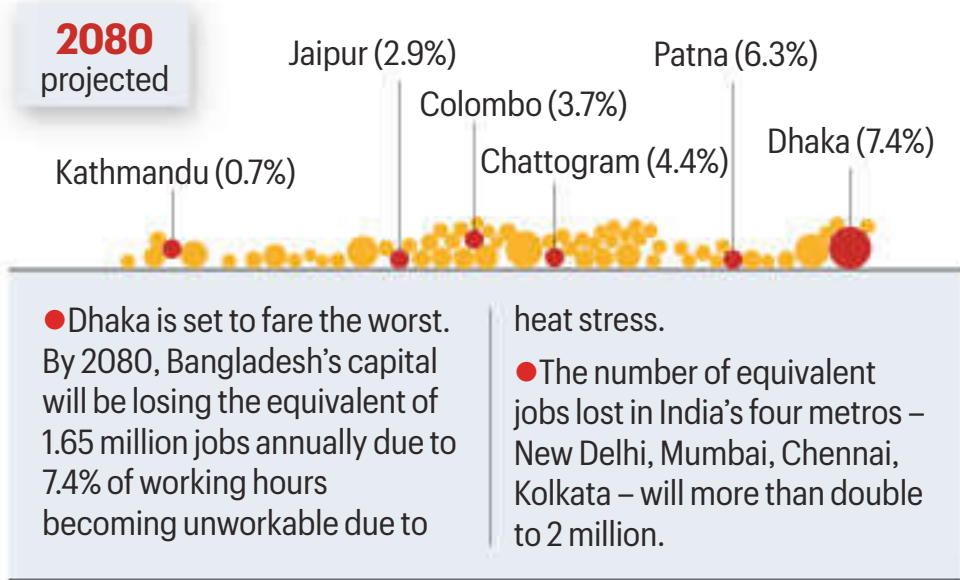
SOURCE: WORLD BANK

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• Extreme heat costing South Asia 31 million jobs

Higher temperatures not only make our cities hot, but also poorer, less productive, and more unequal. According to the World Bank, extreme heat is already costing South Asia the equivalent of 31 million full-time jobs every year as workers slow down, stop early, and fall ill.

Share of annual working hours lost to heat (%) exposure, by city (2030 vs. 2080, SSP2-4.5 emissions scenario)



SOURCE: WORLD BANK

UPI transactions hit record high of Rs 299 lakh cr in July

New Delhi: Transactions through the popular Unified Payments Interface (UPI) again reached a record high of Rs 29.9 lakh crore in July, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

UPI transactions had touched a record high of Rs 29.9 lakh crore in May 2026. As per the data released on Saturday, UPI transactions in volume terms were 23.66 billion in July, higher than 23.2 billion in May and 22.72 billion in June. The value of transactions was at Rs 29.88 lakh crore in July against Rs 25.08 lakh crore in the same month a year ago, registering 19% annual growth. UPI transactions in volume terms were 19.46 billion in June 2026. "UPI continues to strengthen the foundation of India's digital payments ecosystem. In July 2026, it processed 23.66 billion transactions worth Rs 29.88

lakh crore, reaffirming its role as the preferred mode of payment for millions of Indians," PayNearby MD and CEO Anand Kumar Bajaj said.

As UPI adoption deepens, the focus must remain on building trust, awareness and ease of usage at the grassroots, he said, adding that strengthening these foundations will be essential to ensuring that the growth of digital payments translates into wider and more meaningful financial inclusion across Bharat.

UPI is now live in about ten countries, including the UAE, Singapore, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, France, Mauritius, and Qatar, positioning India as a global leader in digital payments. Its growing international adoption is boosting remittances, promoting financial inclusion, and strengthening India's global position in the global fintech landscape. PTI

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July gross GST mop-up grows 15.4% to over Rs 2.11 lakh cr

New Delhi: Gross GST collections grew 15.4% to over Rs 2.11 lakh crore in July on higher mop-up from sales and imports, reflecting sustained domestic consumption. Gross GST collections were Rs 1.8 lakh crore in July 2025 and Rs 1.95 lakh crore last month.

Tax collection from domestic transactions grew 10.1% to over Rs 1.44 lakh crore, while gross revenues from imports were up 29% to Rs 66,511 crore.

Deloitte India Partner M S Mani said the GST collection reflects continued economic resilience despite challenges in the external environment.

"Steady growth in GST collections each month on domestic consumption indicates that overall domestic consumption is becoming largely insulated from seasonal variations and external headwinds," Mani said.

He added that GST collections in July increased in major manufacturing states like Maharashtra, Gujarat and Karnataka. KPMG, Indirect Tax Head & Partner, Abhishek Jain said much of the July GST revenue growth was driven by imports and it would be worth digging into whether that's finished goods or raw materials, and how much of it reflects a weaker rupee rather than higher volumes. PTI

India-China border trade at Nathula resumes after six years

New Delhi: The border trade between India and China through the Nathula Pass resumed on Saturday after six years, marking the revival of one of the oldest trading corridors along the ancient Silk Route, officials said. The trade had remained suspended since 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic and the subsequent strain in India-China border relations. A formal reopening ceremony was held at Nathula in East Sikkim, where officials from the two neighbouring nations participated, signalling the return of seasonal trade through the strategically significant mountain pass at over 14,000 feet. PTI

• SEBI HAS BARRED ZEEL FOUNDER CHANDRA & CEO GOENKA FROM ACCESSING THE SECURITIES MARKET FOR ONE YEAR

How a land parcel used as collateral prompted SEBI to bar ZEEL's Chandra & Goenka

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 1

THE SECURITIES and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has barred Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (ZEEL) founder & chairman emeritus Subhash Chandra and CEO Punit Goenka from accessing the securities market for one year, after finding that the company's immovable property was pledged without authorisation to secure loans raised by promoter-linked entities.

SEBI has also imposed penalties of Rs 60 lakh on Chandra, Rs 58 lakh on Goenka and Rs 30 lakh on ZEEL.

Their firm, ZEEL, has also

been restrained from accessing the securities market for two months. In its final order issued on Friday, SEBI held that land parcels owned by ZEEL in Hyderabad were used as collateral for loans availed by Essel Group entities without the knowledge or approval of the company's board of directors or audit committee.

The transactions were also not disclosed to shareholders or investors, constituting a serious breach of corporate governance and fiduciary responsibilities. The violations relate to transactions carried out in 2018. Privately held firms of the promoter group had taken a loan from the lenders. When

the lender asked for additional security cover, title deeds were handed over to the lender. The pledge was allegedly created without board authorisation and remained undisclosed, depriving shareholders of material information regarding the company's assets.

Assets can't be used for promoter firms

SEBI said that the assets of a listed company are held in trust for all shareholders and cannot be deployed for the benefit of promoter-controlled entities without due corporate approvals and governance safeguards. It held that the unauthorised encumbrance of



ZEEL has also been restrained from accessing the securities market for two months. REUTERS

the company's assets constituted a fraudulent device that prejudiced investor interests

and violated the provisions of the SEBI Act and the Prohibition of Fraudulent and Unfair

• BREAKING PLEDGE

SEBI HELD that land parcels owned by ZEEL in Hyderabad were used as collateral for loans availed by Essel Group entities without the knowledge or approval of the company's board of directors or audit committee

THE TRANSACTIONS were also not disclosed to shareholders or investors, constituting a serious breach of corporate governance and fiduciary responsibilities

Trade Practices (PFUTP) Regulations.

The order follows an inves-

tigation launched after irregularities involving missing title deeds of ZEEL's properties came to light.

During the probe, SEBI found that the security created over the Hyderabad land was intended to facilitate borrowing by promoter-linked entities and was concealed from the board, audit committee and shareholders.

The latest action follows a series of regulatory scrutiny of Zee Entertainment and its promoters. SEBI has investigated multiple allegations relating to diversion of funds, related-party transactions and corporate governance lapses at the broadcaster over the past few

years. While some proceedings resulted in interim and confirmatory orders, others continue under separate legal processes. SEBI said the order reaffirms its commitment to enforcing high standards of corporate governance at listed companies and holding promoters and senior executives accountable for the misuse of corporate assets.

It also underscores the regulator's view that investors are entitled to timely and complete disclosures of transactions involving material company assets, particularly where the interests of promoters conflict with those of minority shareholders.

MEDAL Tally

	Country	G	S	B	Total
1	AUS	61	37	50	148
2	ENG	24	40	34	98
3	CAN	18	18	21	57
4	IND	13	16	8	37
5	SCO	11	8	17	36

*TILL 01/08, 11:45 PM

INDIA watch



Triple jumper Praveen Chithravel. PTI

Chithravel, Selva clinch silver, bronze in triple jump

Praveen Chithravel and Selva Prabhu won silver and bronze medal in the men's triple jump to repeat the double podium after men's javelin throw last night at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. Praveen won the silver medal with a best jump of 16.58m while Selva Prabu won the bronze medal with 16.52m. It was redemption for Praveen who finished a close fourth in the 2022 edition in Birmingham. While Praveen is Asian Games bronze medalist, this was Selva's first major international medal. Jamaica's Jordan Scott won the gold medal in the event with a 16.72m jump. This is the eighth and ninth medal for India in Athletics with a total of five silver medals and four bronze medals. Disappointment continued in the women's 10000m race walk event as well after Priyanka Goswami ended up at seventh despite clocking a season's best 45:53.93. The other Indian in the fray, Ravina, was disqualified. ENS

9 MEDALS & COUNTING IN TRACK AND FIELD, ONE MORE THAN 2022 HAUL

Red-hot Pathirage throws down the gauntlet to Chopra

Lankan wins gold ahead of Asiad; Neeraj, Yash Vir make it double podium for India

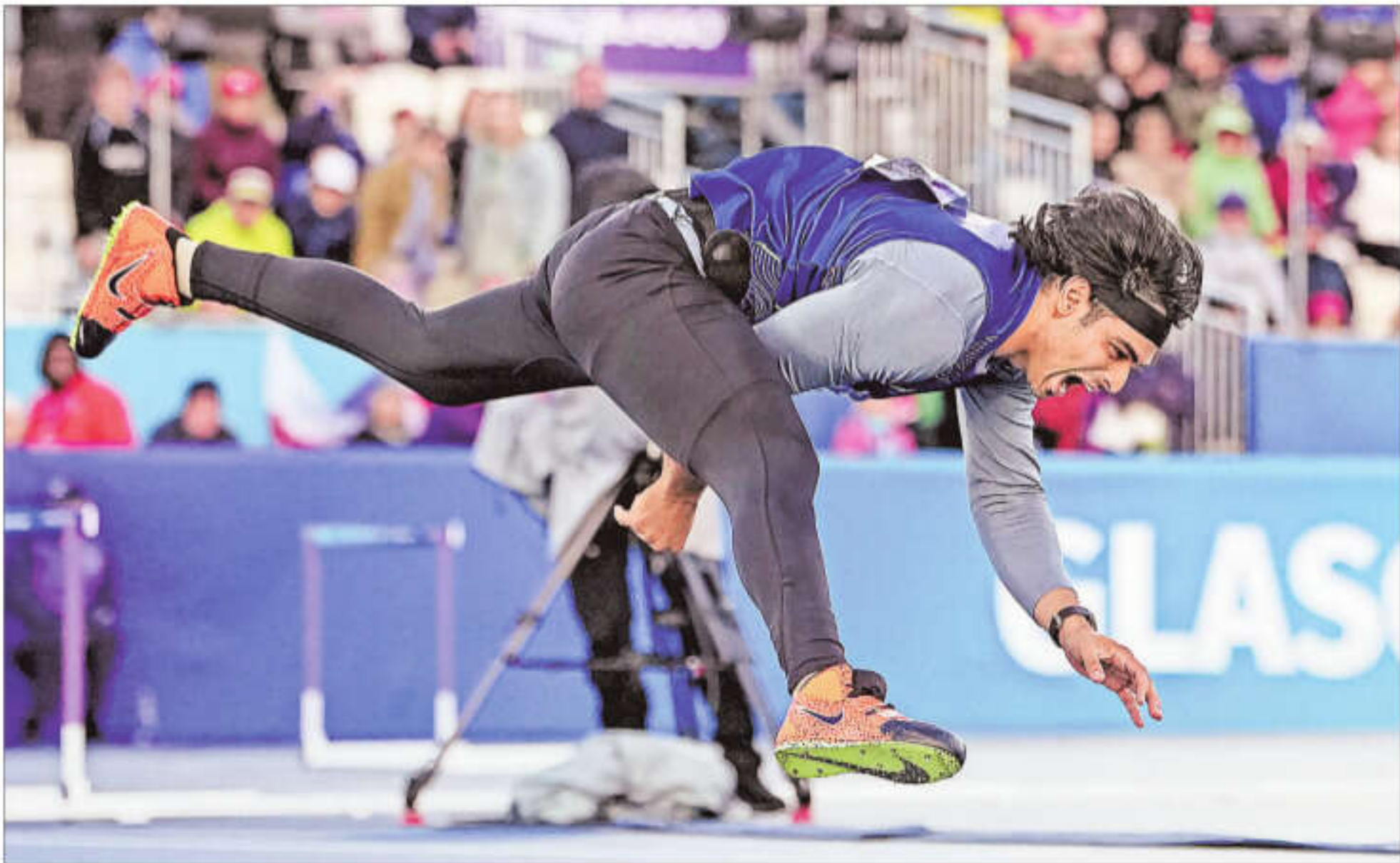
Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, August 1

SRI LANKA'S Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage registered just one legal throw in the final of the men's javelin but with 89.75 metres, he outclassed a world-class field, comprising the Olympic Champion, the World Champion and India's golden boy Neeraj Chopra to win the gold medal at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games.

As compelling as Pathirage's story is - a fast bowler-turned-javelin thrower from an island nation known more for producing sprinters - the bigger picture was the continuing shift in the power centre of the discipline. For the first time at the Commonwealth Games, all three javelin medallists were from South Asia, with Chopra winning the silver (85.83m) and another Indian, Yash Vir Singh, finishing third with 85.41 metres in his sixth and final throw.

Pathirage also showed why he is special. When Chopra went into the provisional first position with 85.83 metres in the second round, the Sri Lankan immediately responded with his best throw of the day, close to 90 metres. From there on, everyone was playing catch-up.

While mainland European nations, the traditional powerhouses in javelin, are hardly a part of the Commonwealth Games, recent results have shown that challengers from other parts of the world are making major progress and



Neeraj Chopra bagged the men's javelin throw silver medal at Commonwealth Games 2026 with a best effort of 85.83m. PTI

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

winning the big medals.

This is not the first time Asians have won major medals in javelin throw. Chopra is an Olympic and World Champion. At the 2024 Paris Olympics, Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem and Chopra completed a 1-2 on the podium, while Grenada's Anderson Peters finished third to mark the first time no European was on the podium in the history of the Summer Games.

At last year's World Championships, a resurgent Keshorn Walcott of Trinidad and Tobago, who stunned the world when he won the 2012 London Olympics gold, finished first. Peters and USA's Curtis Thompson won silver and bronze respectively to keep the Europeans off the podium again.

Kenya's Julius Yego played

The biggest takeaway from Glasgow for India is not the silver medal for Chopra but Yash Vir finishing third

his role in pushing the Europeans aside by winning the 2015 World Championships. No European has won gold at the World Championships or Olympics in nearly a decade.

Lot of contenders

The biggest takeaway from Glasgow for India is not the silver medal for Chopra but Singh finishing third, making a double podium for the country. While Chopra has been the trailblazer by becoming the

first Indian to win gold in track and field at the Olympics or the World Championships, others like Singh have been inspired to dream big.

Singh made a mark when he bettered Chopra's Under-20 Federation Cup record in 2021. But he bided his time before shining on the big stage.

Others like Kishore Kumar Jena (Asian Games silver medallist) and Sachin Yadav (Asian Championship silver medallist) have made an impact, but consistency and bouncing back post injury have been the biggest challenges for those aiming to emulate Chopra.

As for Pathirage, winning gold in tough conditions with headwinds, is a considerable achievement. He had been the only thrower this year to cross

the 90-metre mark, achieved at the Diamond League in Rome last month, to lay down the marker ahead of the Commonwealth Games. While he was undoubtedly talented, the world was waiting to see if he had it in him to deliver in a final when competing among some of the finest in the world.

The fierce competitor in Chopra won't be happy with a second-place finish despite a season-best throw in Glasgow. On his return from a nine-month injury layoff, he had finished fourth at the Doha Diamond League. At the Asian Games, he will again face Pathirage and Nadeem, the reigning Olympic champion. Failure at the CWG will spur the Pakistani to prove a point in Aichi-Nagoya. In global javelin, being the best in Asia carries weight.

'Tejaswin is the complete picture of grit, resilience'



WAYNE LOMBARD

I TRAVEL with Tejaswin Shankar for the majority of his decathlons. At the Commonwealth Games, we knew it would be a challenge for him to do both the high jump and the decathlon.

The flare-up

Tejaswin had this tendon issue for quite some time but we had been able to manage it on most occasions.

The flare-up occurred in the warm-up before the high jump, and he came to me on the side and mentioned it. We tried a few things to see if it could settle down but it didn't get better.

It became very sore by the time of his first jump. The good thing is that TJ knows his body well and if he hadn't pulled out, it would have been very difficult for him to recover.

Was there any doubt that he would be able to participate in the decathlon? For sure, there was doubt. There was doubt right up until he was on the starting blocks for the 100m.

The recovery

After my conversation with Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala, I was relieved. He said there wasn't a significant change in the tendon structures. That's when I knew there was a viable chance of him competing, if we attacked the rehab and recovery as aggressively as possible.

Doc prescribed a few anti-inflammatories, which he took up until the first day of the competition, which helped with pain sensation and exactly what we were going to do with the installation of the tendon.

We wanted to get the knee as quiet as possible. So, in the first 24 hours, the main focus was keeping the knee quiet. So, between the anti-inflammatories, there was a lot of icing and rehab. Instead of one big rehab session, we did two or three smaller rehab sessions throughout the day, just to stimulate that healing process of the tendon. We did some of the isometric-type work. We didn't do eccentric work as it could have caused him more discomfort.

We needed some alternative modalities and that's when I googled to locate a Hyperbaric Chamber that allowed us to put in more oxygen to recover and promote healing.

After that, we used focal red-light therapy that allowed us to stimulate that exact spot where he was feeling pain. We also did some magnetic energy therapy,

which sends magnetic pulses through the entire joint and targets any inflammation within that joint.

With 24 hours gone, we did basic upper-body strength sessions with power movements. It helped us stimulate his central nervous system and keep it primed. We repeated the modalities for the first day as we had got a good response.

Decathlon Day 1 and 2

On the morning of the event, he felt really good. He did his warm-up in the hotel gym. While leaning on the starting blocks, he felt confident. I have known TJ for 10 years now and know how his body responds. So, I knew that he would start the event well.

Tejaswin started slow off the blocks in 100m but then did a massive jump in the second event which gave him a lot of confidence. The tendon didn't flare up during the long jump or the high jump. He looked like he was in pain but eventually the pain subsided.

After he came back, we did the set routine for recoveries and he went off to sleep as it was necessary to get as much rest as possible.

When I met him in the morning, he said it felt like a normal day two and that was the best response I could get as it meant there was no sign of tendon inflammation or flare.

We went for a hot bath rather than cold because I felt that it would be better for the tendon as it was chilly outside. He did some mobility and isometrics with me and looked good to go. The second day was much better than the first as his knee was responding and he looked more comfortable in the 110m hurdles than he looked in the 100m.

Mental resolve

When he came back after the injury, he was really emotional. He felt that he had let everyone down and I felt my role there was to just support him and let him express his emotions. Once he was done with negative thoughts, I said that I am here to deal with all this and let me work on him. After we were done, it was all TJ.

For someone to go into an event knowing they're only 80 percent and take it one step at a time, concentrating on each event without letting the pain and sensation of their tendon disrupt his performance, gives a complete picture of grit and resilience. That's just who TJ is.

(Dr Wayne Lombard is a renowned strength and conditioning coach and works with elite Indian athletes. He talked to Pritish Raj.)



Tejaswin claimed India's maiden decathlon medal at CWG. AP

Yash saves best for last to script success post surgery

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, August 1

YASH VIR SINGH was expected to go places when he broke Neeraj Chopra's Under-20 Federation Cup record five years ago. A shoulder surgery in late 2023 set him back as it took him nearly a year to throw in a competition again.

In the meantime, others moved up the pecking order; Kishore Kumar Jena won an Asian Games silver medal, while Sachin Yadav came second at the Asian Championships. But when the stars aligned, the 24-year-old son of a former Railways javelin champion, stepped up with his best effort to win a bronze at the Commonwealth Games and make it a double podium finish, along with Chopra who won the silver.

In cold and windy conditions, Chopra produced his biggest throw of 85.83 metres in the second round, also his season's best. Yash Vir left it for the last round.

After his five prior throws, his best of 81.33m had placed him sixth. Reigning World Champion Keshorn Walcott's last attempt of 82.55m had pushed Yash Vir to seventh place before he came up with a personal best of 85.41 to clinch a bronze, his first major international medal.

While watching his son compete in Glasgow, Rai Singh said he didn't feel any nerves, even when he was well outside the medal standings after round five.

"There was wind but in javelin, a 2-3 metre improvement can happen suddenly because there are so many factors. He had thrown well in practice, it was just a question of getting that one good throw. I just told him to be confident because he has a big throw in him. Thankfully, he produced it at the right time," Rai, who hails from the boxing hotbed of Bhiwani, said.

Yash Vir started training for javelin at the age of 13. His first coach was his father, who has won multiple national medals.



Yash Vir Singh came up with a personal best of 85.41 metres. PTI

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

Though Rai's parents live in Devsar in Bhiwani, a nursery of Olympian boxers, he wanted to keep his son away from the ring. Yash Vir grew up in Jaipur but would often visit his paternal grandparents.

"Even if you win, you get punched in boxing. I did not

want him to get into boxing. If he was to take up some sport, it had to be javelin throw. When there is a coach at home, why try any other sport? Today, he has achieved what I could not. In a way, I am living my dream through him," Rai said on Saturday.

MEDAL SURGE IN BOXING

Indian boxers a class apart as seven golds set a new standard

Apart from three pugilists, every Indian who entered the ring tasted victory in the final

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, August 1

A SINGLE boxer was yet to step into the ring on Saturday when India had already broken Commonwealth Games boxing records. Ten assured medals before a punch was thrown on the final day of the boxing programme in Glasgow. Weakened field or not, it's a rare feat in Indian boxing, especially considering the administrative mess that the sport finds itself in the country.

The seven gold medals and three silver won by the pugilists makes India the top boxing contingent at the 2026 Commonwealth Games and sets up the Ahmedabad edition four years hence rather well.

With traditional strong suits like shooting, wrestling and badminton absent from the diluted Commonwealth Games, boxing was the only discipline where Indian muscles could be flexed.

After finishing second in the medal tally at Gold Coast 2018 (3 x Gold, 3 x Silver, 3 x Bronze) and Birmingham 2022 (3 x Gold, 1 x Silver, 3 x Bronze), anything under eight medals would have been considered a regression.

But India's team, especially the women boxers, have steadily ascended towards the top at the world level over the last year, and continued that same run without many of the heavy hitters from England and Australia.

Sakshi Chaudhary — who replaced Nikhat Zareen in the 51kg category — Preeti Pawar, Jaismine Lamboria and Lovlina Borgohain are all capable of being in the mix for multi-sport event medals.

They form the backbone of a strong all-weather women's team that can go toe-to-toe against some of the best boxing countries in the world. Priya Ghanghas added a gold to the tally as well and concluded a successful campaign for the In-



India's Jaismine (R) and Michaela Walsh of Northern Ireland compete in the women's 57kg boxing final. AP Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

● Rocking in the ring



India's Preeti Pawar reacts after winning against Canada's Scarlett Delgado. PTI

BOXER	CATEGORY	RESULT
Women		
Preeti Pawar	54 kg	Gold
Jaismine Lamboria	57 kg	Gold
Sakshi Chaudhary	51 kg	Gold
Priya Ghanghas	60 kg	Gold
Arundhati Choudhary	70 kg	Gold
Lovlina Borgohain	75 kg	Silver
Men		
Sachin Siwach	60 kg	Gold
Ankush Panghal	80 kg	Gold
Jadumani Singh	55 kg	Silver
Narender	90+ kg	Silver

*TILL 11:30 PM

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1currentWorldsbronze medalist Emma Sue Greentree of Australia and suffered a 1-4 loss in a contest that went down to the wire before the Assamese boxer's in-bout fatigue management – a familiar issue that has been plaguing her since moving up weight categories after her Tokyo Olympic bronze

medal – decided the fight in her opponent's favour.

Best in business

Jaismine is the reigning world champion in the 57kg class. But at 25, she is still learning how to use her considerable gifts in her category. On Saturday, she was provided yet another test of her range – this time against Michaela Walsh, a boxer who has medals from the 2014, 2018, 2022 and now the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Walsh is the typical of boxers that Jaismine struggles against – shorter but skillful in short bursts when moving inside. But the world champion has continued her growth and showcased it in the win.

Out of all Indian women's gold medals on Saturday, Jaismine went through the toughest bout and came out on the other side with a gold to add to her already burgeoning medal cabinet.

Later Olympic Gold Quest CEO Viren Rasquinha said that the Indian had got little time to practice ahead of the CWG.

"40 days ago, Jaismine was

in hospital for continuous high fever and stomach issues. She had only three weeks of training post recovery. Today, she wins GOLD at CWG after beating the reigning Champion from NIR," he tweeted.

Perhaps the best Indian boxer at the event was the one with the easiest bouts on her hand.

Smooth run

The 54kg category in India itself is a minefield with multiple boxers vying for the spot. Competition has been fierce for years. But at the Commonwealth Games, Preeti's run to the gold medal was as smooth as it could get.

There is an argument to be made that the CWG gold was easier than some of the national competitions that she has competed in.

The southpaw easily landed the best shots among all Indians.

The most eye-catching among them was a blow from the right, masked as an uppercut but landing as a cross, used on multiple occasions.

Arundhati from Kota shines in the ring, with help from YouTube

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, August 1



Arundhati Choudhary won gold in the 70 kg category. AP

IT'S TOUGH to find a subject for which there isn't a tutor in the city of Kota, but Suresh Choudhary and his studious daughter managed to do the unimaginable: their search for a subject-matter expert failed, because Kota did not have a single boxing coach.

The daughter in question, Arundhati Choudhary, won gold in the women's 70kg on Saturday at the SEC Centre in Glasgow, one of seven Indians to win gold on a record-breaking day for India's boxing programme at these Commonwealth Games.

"She used to enjoy playing all sports, but basketball was the one she used to play regularly. She was the captain of her school team. I used to try to convince her that there is no career in sports and to focus completely on studies. But when she was in 6th standard, we had a fight because she wanted to continue playing sport, and I felt that 'Kota ka mahaul padhai ke liye bohot acha hai' — Kota's environment is very good for studies," says Suresh.

"All of India comes here to study. But she threw a tantrum and insisted she wanted to play sports."

Suresh came around, on a compromise: she could play sport, but one where her individual excellence could shine rather than get lost in a team game. Basketball was out. Wrestling and shooting were discussed, but Suresh says his daughter's eyes lit up when she realised boxing was an Olympic sport. A girl known for picking fights with kids at school, Arundhati had just found out that what she did in the schoolyard could become a profession. Finding a coach, though, stumped them both.

Eventually they landed at the doorstep of Ashok Gautam, a local instructor who taught martial arts like wushu and taekwondo. Gautam admitted he knew nothing about boxing. So he started watching Muhammad Ali and Mike Tyson videos on YouTube, working through whatever instructional footage other coaches had uploaded, and relaying what he learned back to Arundhati.

Kota had found itself another tutor, and a future boxing gold medalist.

It wasn't until Arundhati was 16, and reached the junior nationals despite barely any competition to prepare her in Kota,

that her father realised boxing was serious. When she forced a referee to stop a contest against a boxer from Haryana, the state that has long dominated Indian contact sports, Suresh finally accepted that only one of his daughters was going to be the studious one, and it wasn't going to be the one boxing.

Carrying injury

Twenty-three now, Arundhati won this medal the way many athletes at these Games have: carrying an injury. "She has a plate near her wrist from an injury she suffered earlier. Her other wrist needs to be looked at as well, and she also has a linear fracture in her heel," Suresh says. Surgery would have meant inactivity, and inactivity, in a competitive Indian boxing scene, risks losing your spot to someone else.

That fear was real for years before it ever became a medal story.

Arundhati spent a long stretch on the sidelines because she shared a weight class with Lovlina Borgohain, whose height and reach carried her to Olympic and Asian Games medals. Once Lovlina moved up to 75kg, Arundhati finally got her run in the team. There was a kind of vindication, then, in beating Rosie Eccles in the semi-final, the same Welsh boxer who had beaten Lovlina a weight class above at Birmingham in 2022.

In the final, it was another India-England contest, the two countries that have traded blows at the top of CWG boxing standings for years. Arundhati convinced all five judges, a unanimous decision over her English opponent, for gold.

● SWIFT REVERSAL

In a U-turn, FIFA scraps World Cup stake sale proposal; UEFA 'loses confidence'

Reuters
August 1

UEFA SAID it had lost confidence in FIFA President Gianni Infantino on Saturday after world football's governing body abandoned plans to sell a stake in the commercial rights to the World Cup.

FIFA's proposal had triggered a fierce backlash from regional confederations who said they had been blindsided by Infantino's plans to raise up to \$4.2 billion by selling about a 20% stake to private investors in a new unit that would run FIFA events, including the World Cup.

The swift reversal has ex-

posed growing unease within world soccer over Infantino's leadership style, with football officials demanding greater oversight of decisions that could reshape the governance and commercial future of the sport. UEFA, whose 55 members had unanimously rejected the proposal earlier this week, declared FIFA's retreat a "victory for the whole game" while adding that the "task of rebuilding trust in FIFA" had only just begun.

"The current FIFA leadership has not only lost UEFA's confidence but also that of many other members of the football family," UEFA said in a statement.

"UEFA thanks all the fans, leagues, clubs, players, individuals, associations and confederations that opposed the scheme, alongside the many Prime Ministers, Heads of State and commentators who have demonstrated to the FIFA President that football is not for sale," it said in a statement.

"We cannot keep going on like this with secret schemes on fast-track timescales, cooked up by faceless individuals and of dubious benefit to the game. We must identify those responsible and hold them to account." The backlash raised questions about Infantino's political capital as he prepares to seek another term in office.



FIFA president Gianni Infantino had earlier announced plans to sell a stake in the commercial rights to the World Cup. REUTERS

The controversy comes at an awkward moment for Infantino, who said in April he intends to seek re-election for a fourth term as FIFA president.

UEFA reminded Infantino about the promises he made when he was elected FIFA president in 2016 — vowing to work with transparency and saying FIFA's money belonged to the national associations.

"On both these promises, he has failed to deliver. The shabby, back-room, opaque deal he hatched and tried to force through was anything but transparent," UEFA added.

"And with reserves standing at over \$5 billion, he has also failed to use associations' money for the benefit of the game. UEFA will begin work immediately with partners and stakeholders all over the world and right across the game to propose a new way of distributing resources through the existing FIFA Forward programme."

FIFA and Infantino declined to comment on UEFA's statement.

Infantino's plan, announced on Tuesday, quickly ran into a storm of opposition from regional confederations, who complained they had not been consulted on a move that could alter the commercial structure of world football.

Following the backlash, Infantino said world soccer's governing body had abandoned the plans after listening "carefully to all the views".

The controversy comes at an awkward moment for Infantino, who said in April he intends to seek re-election for a fourth term as FIFA president.

Since taking over from Sepp Blatter in 2016, he has been re-elected unopposed twice.